いただきます

ITADAKIMASU · "LET'S EAT"

17
PHRASE CARDS INCLUDED

A JAPAN RESIDENT'S GUIDE

How to Order Food in Japan

Ramen ticket machines, izakaya, conveyor-belt sushi and tablet ordering — exactly how they work, plus phrase cards you can simply show to staff.

Ticket machines | Izakaya | Conveyor-belt sushi | Tablet & QR ordering | Paying

18	17	50+	1
pages	phrase cards to show staff	menu & sign words decoded	printable cheat sheet

Printable · Phone-friendly

2026 edition

START HERE

How to use this guide

The places visitors find most confusing — the ramen shop with a machine at the door, the izakaya where a dish you didn't order appears — are often where the best food is. This guide removes the guesswork.

BEFORE YOU GO

Read Parts 1–7

About 15 minutes. You'll walk into any restaurant knowing what's about to happen.

AT THE TABLE

Show the cards

Open Part 8 on your phone, turn the screen toward staff and point. No speaking needed.

IN YOUR WALLET

Print the cheat sheet

The last page fits everything essential on one sheet.

Contents

1 **Before You Go** 3
Tipping, free water, calling staff, cash vs card, smoking

2 **Ticket Machines** 4
Ramen, soba, udon and set-meal shops · button decoder

3 **Tablet & QR Ordering** 6
The words you'll see on screen

4 **Izakaya** 7
What "otoshi" is, ordering in rounds, all-you-can-drink

5 **Conveyor-Belt Sushi** 9
Touch panels, plates, making your own green tea

6 **Paying & Leaving** 11
Where to pay, splitting the bill, the cash tray

7 **Etiquette That Actually Matters** 12
...and what you can stop worrying about

8 **Phrase Cards** 13
17 cards to show staff + what staff will say to you

✂ **One-Page Cheat Sheet** 17
Print it, fold it, keep it

PART 1

Before You Go

行く前に知っておくこと

Six things every Japanese person knows — and almost no first-time visitor does.

1. No tipping. Ever.
Service is part of the price. If you leave money on the table, a staff member may run after you to give it back. A sincere "thank you" is the tip.

2. Water and tea are free
They often arrive as soon as you sit down. At some shops it's self-service — look for a water jug or dispenser near the counter.

3. "Sumimasen!" calls staff
Raise your hand and call out **sumimasen** ("excuse me"). It isn't rude — it's how it works. Many tables also have a call button.

4. The wet towel is for your hands
That's the *oshibori*. Use it to clean your hands before eating. Leave it folded beside your plate.

5. Cash still matters
Cards and IC cards (Suica, PASMO, ICOCA) are accepted in more places every year, but small, long-running shops can be cash-only. Carry ¥1,000 notes and coins.

6. Most places are non-smoking
Since April 2020, restaurants are non-smoking indoors by default. Some small, long-established bars and izakaya may still allow it — look for a sign at the entrance.

Signs worth recognising

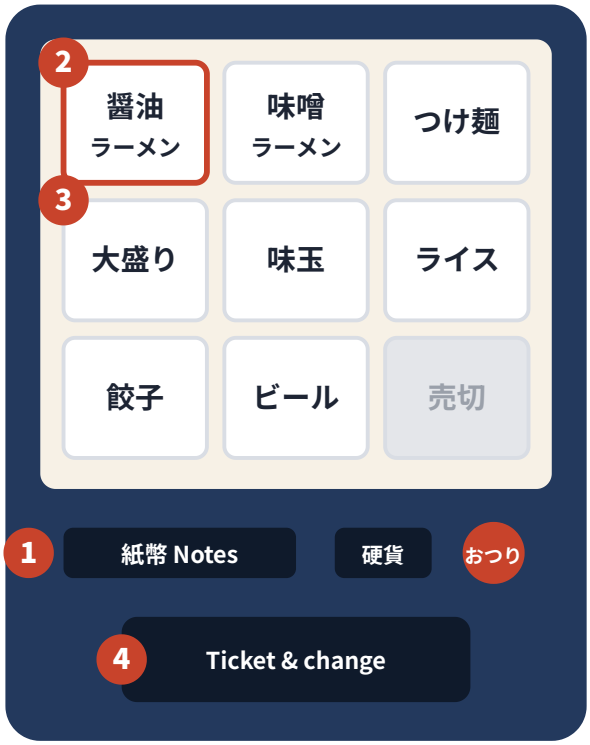
営業中	*eigyō-chū*	Open	**準備中**	*junbi-chū*	Closed / preparing
禁煙	*kin'en*	No smoking	**喫煙可**	*kitsuen-ka*	Smoking allowed
満席	*manseki*	Full	**現金のみ**	*genkin nomi*	Cash only

PART 2

Ticket Machines

券売機・食券機

At many ramen, soba, udon and set-meal shops you **pay before you sit down**. If there's a machine near the door, that's where your meal starts.



1. **Insert money first**
   Notes or coins. Lit buttons show what you can now buy. Some newer machines let you choose first, then pay by card or IC card.
2. **Press your dish**
   One button = one ticket.
3. **Add extras**
   Large size, egg, rice — each is a separate button and a separate ticket.
4. **Take your ticket(s) and change**
   If change doesn't drop, press **おつり** (otsuri).
5. **Hand the tickets to staff**
   ...or place them on the counter in front of your seat. Then sit where you're shown.

Bring ¥1,000 notes

Some machines don't accept ¥10,000 notes, or the new banknotes issued in 2024. Keep a few ¥1,000 notes and coins for ramen shops.

Can't read the buttons?

Buttons with photos are your friend. The **top-left button is often the shop's signature dish**. Point your phone's camera translator at the machine — or show card 12 to staff.

PART 2 · CONTINUED

Button Decoder

ボタンの読み方

The dish

BUTTON	SAY	MEANS
醤油	*shōyu*	Soy-sauce broth
味噌	*miso*	Miso broth
塩	*shio*	Salt broth (light)
豚骨	*tonkotsu*	Pork-bone broth (rich)
つけ麺	*tsukemen*	Noodles you dip
定食	*teishoku*	Set meal (rice, soup, sides)
単品	*tanpin*	Dish only, no set
売切	*urikire*	Sold out

Size & extras

BUTTON	SAY	MEANS
並	*nami*	Regular size
大盛り	*ōmori*	Large size
小盛り	*komori*	Small size
味玉	*ajitama*	Seasoned soft-boiled egg
チャーシュー	*chāshū*	Sliced roast pork
替玉	*kaedama*	Extra noodles (refill)
ライス	*raisu*	Bowl of rice
餃子	*gyōza*	Pan-fried dumplings

What staff may ask after you hand over the ticket

At some ramen shops — especially rich, pork-bone styles — staff ask how you'd like your bowl.

麺の硬さは？	*Men no katasa wa?*	How firm would you like your noodles?
硬め ／ 普通 ／ 柔らかめ	*katame / futsū / yawarakame*	Firm / regular / soft
味の濃さ ／ 油の量	*aji no kosa / abura no ryō*	Flavour strength / amount of oil

The insider shortcut: when in doubt, answer **"futsū"** (regular) to everything. It's always a safe, normal answer.

PART 3

Tablet & QR Ordering

タブレット・QRコード注文

More and more restaurants let you order from a tablet at your table or from your own phone. Usually it's the easiest way to order — once you know the words.

TABLET AT YOUR TABLE

1. **Find the language button**
   Look for EN, English, 言語 or a globe icon.
2. **Add items to your order**
   Choose quantity, then add.
3. **Confirm the order**
   Press 注文する or 注文確定. **Nothing arriving? You probably didn't confirm.**

QR CODE ON THE TABLE

1. **Scan the code**
   with your phone camera. The menu opens in your browser.
2. **Order from your phone**
   Your order history stays on the page.
3. **Check how to pay**
   Some shops take payment on the phone; most still ask you to pay at the register.

Words you'll see on screen

ON SCREEN	SAY	MEANS	ON SCREEN	SAY	MEANS
注文	*chūmon*	Order	**確定**	*kakutei*	Confirm
追加	*tsuika*	Add more	**取消**	*torikeshi*	Cancel
注文履歴	*chūmon rireki*	Order history	**戻る**	*modoru*	Back
店員呼出	*ten'in yobidashi*	Call staff	**お会計**	*okaikei*	The bill / check

> **Tip:** before you leave the table, press **お会計** if the screen has it. It tells staff you're ready — and some systems print or display what you owe.

PART 4

Izakaya

居酒屋

A Japanese pub where the food matters as much as the drinks. Dishes are small, shared, and ordered a few at a time — the evening unfolds in rounds.

The dish you didn't order: お通し (otōshi)

Soon after you sit down, a small dish arrives that you didn't ask for. That's the **otoshi** — think of it as a **seat charge that comes with a snack**.

It's usually **about ¥300–500 per person**, but can be ¥1,000 or more at upscale places or in tourist areas. On the bill it may appear as "charge" or "seat fee" (チャージ／席料). It's normally not something you can refuse.

If it matters to you, ask before you sit: **お通しはありますか？** *(Otōshi wa arimasu ka?)* — "Is there an otoshi charge?"

How an evening works

1. **Drinks come first**
   Staff will ask for your first drink almost immediately. "Toriaezu biiru" — "beer for now" — is the classic opener. You don't have to order food yet.

2. **Order a few dishes, not everything**
   Two or three to start. More will follow.

3. **Everything is shared**
   Dishes go in the middle of the table. Ask for small plates: **取り皿** (torizara).

4. **Order more in rounds**
   Call "sumimasen!" whenever you want the next round.

5. **"Last order"**
   Staff announce **ラストオーダー** before closing — your final chance to add anything.

The Izakaya Menu

居酒屋のメニュー

Drinks

MENU	SAY	MEANS
生ビール	*nama biiru*	Draft beer
ハイボール	*haibōru*	Whisky & soda
サワー	*sawā*	Fruit shōchū soda
日本酒	*nihonshu*	Sake
ソフトドリンク	*sofuto dorinku*	Non-alcoholic

Food

MENU	SAY	MEANS
枝豆	*edamame*	Salted soybeans
焼き鳥	*yakitori*	Grilled chicken skewers
唐揚げ	*karaage*	Fried chicken
刺身	*sashimi*	Sliced raw fish
だし巻き玉子	*dashimaki tamago*	Rolled omelette

飲み放題 (nomihōdai) — all you can drink

A fixed price for unlimited drinks within a time limit, often 90–120 minutes. Many places ask everyone at the table to take it if one person does. Ask the time limit and the last-order time.

〆 (shime) — the finisher

Many people end the night with something simple — rice, noodles or *ochazuke* (tea poured over rice). If you see 〆 on the menu, that's the section.

Reading a menu with no English? Many izakaya have a handwritten board of today's specials. Photograph it and run it through your phone's translator — or simply point at what the next table is eating and show card 6.

PART 5

Conveyor-Belt Sushi

回転寿司

Cheap, fun and fast — and the big chains are built for people who don't speak Japanese. Here's what to expect from the door to the bill.

1. **Check in at the entrance**
   Many chains have a reception machine. Choose table or counter and the number of people; take the ticket and wait until your number appears on the screen.
2. **Switch the touch panel to English**
   Each seat has a screen. Most big chains offer English and other languages.
3. **Order on the panel**
   What you order arrives on a separate lane or a marked plate, and the screen tells you when it's yours.
   Take only your own order.
4. **Or take plates from the belt**
   At shops where sushi still circulates, you can take any plate that passes.
5. **Ask for the bill on the panel**
   Press the check button (**お会計**), then pay at the register on the way out.

Never put a plate back

Once a plate is off the belt, it's yours. Stack your empty plates — some chains have a slot at your seat to drop them into, which counts them for you.

How much is a plate?

Some chains price by **plate colour** (there's a chart on the wall or panel); others are mostly flat-price. Basic plates start around ¥110 at the big chains.

PART 5 · CONTINUED

At Your Seat

席にあるもの

Make your own green tea

粉茶 powder → cup 1 spoon → お湯 hot tap

Push the cup against the tap at your seat · very hot

The green powder in the container on your table is tea (粉茶, kona-cha) — not wasabi.

Free at your seat

ガリ	*gari*	Pickled ginger — between bites
醤油	*shōyu*	Soy sauce
わさび	*wasabi*	Often in small packets

At many big chains, sushi comes **without wasabi** so children can eat it. Add your own from the packets.

Sushi words

WORD	SAY	MEANS	WORD	SAY	MEANS
さび抜き	*sabinuki*	No wasabi	**炙り**	*aburi*	Lightly seared
軍艦	*gunkan*	Seaweed-wrapped, topped	**一貫**	*ikkan*	One piece
まぐろ	*maguro*	Tuna	**サーモン**	*sāmon*	Salmon
えび	*ebi*	Shrimp	**いか**	*ika*	Squid
玉子	*tamago*	Sweet omelette	**茶碗蒸し**	*chawanmushi*	Savoury egg custard

PART 6

Paying & Leaving

お会計

Paying is simple once you know one rule: look for the bill on your table.

Bill on the table → pay at the register

If staff left a slip on your table (often in a holder), take it to the register by the exit when you're done.

No bill → ask at your table

Say **"Okaikei onegaishimasu"** (card 14). Staff will bring the bill or point you to the register.

Use the small tray

At the register there's usually a small tray. Place your cash or card on it rather than handing it over directly. Your change comes back on the tray, too.

Splitting the bill

Ask **"Betsubetsu de onegaishimasu"** (card 16). Many casual places will split it; when it's busy, some prefer a single payment.

The words that make staff smile

On your way out, say **ごちそうさまでした** *(gochisōsama deshita)* — "thank you for the meal." It's what Japanese customers say, and staff genuinely appreciate hearing it from visitors.

Reminder: no tip — not on the table, not in the tray. The price you see is the price you pay.

PART 7

Etiquette That Actually Matters

本当に大事なマナーだけ

Visitors often worry far too much about "doing it wrong." Here's the short list that matters — and the longer list you can stop worrying about.

Worth getting right

Chopsticks: two things to avoid

Don't pass food from your chopsticks to someone else's, and don't stand chopsticks upright in rice. Both are associated with funerals.

Wait to be seated

Don't take an empty table on your own unless staff gesture for you to sit anywhere.

Eating while walking

In some busy tourist areas it's discouraged. If you buy street food, eat it by the stall where you bought it.

You can relax about

Slurping noodles

Perfectly normal. Nobody will think twice.

Lifting your bowl

Holding a rice or soup bowl up near your mouth is the normal way to eat.

Not speaking Japanese

Nobody expects you to. A smile, pointing and the cards in this guide are more than enough.

PART 8

Phrase Cards

見せるだけで伝わる

Turn your screen toward staff and point to the card. Big Japanese is for them; the small lines are for you.

ENTERING 01

2名です。

Ni-mei desu.

Table for two.

ENTERING 02

予約していません。入れますか？

Yoyaku shite imasen. Hairemasu ka?

No reservation. Can we get a table?

ENTERING 03

〇〇の名前で予約しています。

___ no namae de yoyaku shite imasu.

I have a reservation under ___.

ENTERING 04

英語のメニューはありますか？

Eigo no menyū wa arimasu ka?

Do you have an English menu?

ORDERING 05

すみません！

Sumimasen!

Excuse me! (to call staff)

ORDERING 06

これをください。

Kore o kudasai.

This one, please. (point)

Phrase Cards

ORDERING 07

これを2つください。

Kore o futatsu kudasai.

Two of these, please.

ORDERING 08

おすすめは何ですか？

Osusume wa nan desu ka?

What do you recommend?

ORDERING 09

大盛りでお願いします。

Ōmori de onegaishimasu.

Large portion, please.

ORDERING 10

お水をください。

Omizu o kudasai.

Water, please.

ORDERING 11

取り皿をください。

Torizara o kudasai.

Small plates for sharing, please.

TICKET MACHINE 12

食券はどこで買いますか？

Shokken wa doko de kaimasu ka?

Where do I buy the meal ticket?

Phrase Cards

TICKET MACHINE 13

現金だけですか？

Genkin dake desu ka?

Is it cash only?

PAYING 14

お会計お願いします。

Okaikei onegaishimasu.

Check, please.

PAYING 15

カードは使えますか？

Kādo wa tsukaemasu ka?

Can I pay by card?

PAYING 16

別々でお願いします。

Betsubetsu de onegaishimasu.

Separate checks, please.

LEAVING 17

ごちそうさまでした。

Gochisōsama deshita.

Thank you for the meal.

PART 8 · CONTINUED

What Staff Will Say to You

店員さんがよく言うこと

You don't need to answer in Japanese — just recognising these will tell you what's happening.

YOU'LL HEAR	SOUNDS LIKE	MEANS	WHAT TO DO
いらっしゃいませ	*irasshaimase*	Welcome!	Nothing — a nod or smile is perfect
何名様ですか？	*nan-mei-sama desu ka?*	How many people?	Show fingers, or card 1
少々お待ちください	*shōshō omachi kudasai*	Please wait a moment	Wait near the entrance
お決まりですか？	*okimari desu ka?*	Ready to order?	Point and show card 6
満席です	*manseki desu*	We're full	Ask how long, or try elsewhere
お通しです	*otōshi desu*	Your table-charge appetizer	Enjoy it (see Part 4)
ラストオーダーです	*rasuto ōdā desu*	Last orders	Add anything final now
ありがとうございました	*arigatō gozaimashita*	Thank you (as you leave)	"Gochisōsama deshita!"

✂ PRINT & KEEP

One-Page Cheat Sheet

これ1枚で大丈夫

2名です。	*Ni-mei desu.*	Table for two.
英語のメニューはありますか？	*Eigo no menyū wa arimasu ka?*	English menu?
すみません！	*Sumimasen!*	Excuse me! (call staff)
これをください。	*Kore o kudasai.*	This one, please.
おすすめは何ですか？	*Osusume wa nan desu ka?*	What do you recommend?
お水をください。	*Omizu o kudasai.*	Water, please.
お会計お願いします。	*Okaikei onegaishimasu.*	Check, please.
カードは使えますか？	*Kādo wa tsukaemasu ka?*	Can I pay by card?
ごちそうさまでした。	*Gochisōsama deshita.*	Thank you for the meal.

Remember

- ✔ **No tipping.** Ever.
- ✔ **Bring ¥1,000 notes** for machines.
- ✔ **Never** put a sushi plate back.
- ✔ **Bill on the table?** Pay at the register.
- ✔ **Ticket machine?** Pay before you sit.
- ✔ **Otoshi** = seat charge with a snack.
- ✔ **"Futsū"** is always a safe answer.
- ✔ **Water and tea** are free.

ABOUT THIS GUIDE

Enjoy every meal.

いってらっしゃい

How this guide was made

Written and checked by a native Japanese speaker living in Japan. AI tools assisted with drafting, layout, diagrams and English editing. Every Japanese phrase was reviewed by a native speaker.

Please note

This guide explains how ordering generally works in Japan. It does not recommend specific restaurants, and it is not affiliated with any restaurant or chain. Systems, prices and rules vary from shop to shop and change over time; prices mentioned are typical examples as of 2025–2026.

Personal use

This file is for your personal use. Please don't resell, share or redistribute it. Printing copies for your own travel group is fine.

Found this useful? A short review helps other travellers find it — and tells me which guide to make next.